



FOR YEARS, mental healthcare in India occupied an uncomfortable space, largely spoken about through the lens of stigma, celebrity advocacy, and awareness campaigns. The conversation revolved around convincing people that it was acceptable to seek help. Today, that narrative is changing. The bigger question is no longer whether Indians recognise mental health as important but whether the country can build a sustainable mental healthcare industry capable of

serving a rapidly growing demand.

That shift is visible across ecosystems. Digital-first start-ups are expanding therapy and psychiatric services, specialist providers are building integrated care models, hospitals are investing in dedicated psychiatric facilities, employers are embedding mental wellness into employee benefits, and insurers are slowly bringing mental health into mainstream coverage. Investors, too, are beginning to view the category not as a niche wellness play but as an emerging healthcare vertical.

“Mental healthcare is becoming a real healthcare sector. I don’t see it as a fast-growing app or a wellness category anymore,” says Amit Malik, Founder & CEO, Amaha, a mental health start-up providing online and in-person psychiatric care, professional therapy, and self-care apps.

“The conversation has shifted from creating awareness to building delivery,” Malik adds.

AWARENESS TO ACTION

The pandemic undoubtedly accelerated conversations around mental well-being, but operators say the momentum has outlasted Covid. Consumers are increasingly seeking therapy as part of preventive healthcare.

Dr Ritika Sinha, Co-founder of Rocket Health, believes digital adoption has fundamentally changed access. Rocket Health is a digital mental health platform, started in 2021, which operates as a marketplace.

“During the pandemic, even people who were sceptical about mental healthcare became comfortable seeking consultations virtually. That behavioural shift has stayed. Today, mental healthcare has become normal for many consumers, especially Gen Zs,” says Sinha.

The change is visible in Rocket

A HEALTHY MIND

➤ **The conversation around mental healthcare has shifted from reducing stigma to building scalable businesses**

➤ **While therapy adoption is rising, the industry’s biggest bottleneck is a shortage of practice-ready psychologists and psychiatrists**

➤ **Companies are expanding into psychiatry, hospitals, rehabilitation. Investors believe full-stack clinical infra will create sustainable businesses**

➤ **The pandemic normalised virtual consultations, while Gen Z has reframed therapy as part of preventive wellness**

➤ **Long-term success will hinge on making mental healthcare affordable without compromising quality**